

► UNDERSTANDING COLOUR

Understanding the basic principles of colour theory is crucial to designing a successful quilt. Even a simple design gains impact from good colour choices. The three primary colours (red, yellow, and blue) can be placed side by side to create a colour wheel. When

two primary colours are combined, they create “secondaries”. Red and yellow make orange, yellow and blue make green, and blue and red make purple. Intermediate colours called tertiaries occur when a secondary is mixed with the nearest primary.



Monochromatic designs:

These use different versions of the same colour. So a quilt based on greens will not stray into the other sections of the colour wheel, but will only use green fabric.



Complementary colours:

Colours that lie opposite one another on the wheel, such as yellow and violet, or red and green, are called complementaries. They provide contrasts that accent design elements and make both colours stand out. Don't forget black and white, the ultimate opposites.



Analogous colours (side

by side): Starting with a primary or dominant colour, expand in each direction on the colour wheel by one colour. Similar to a Monochromatic colour scheme, but with a bit more variation.



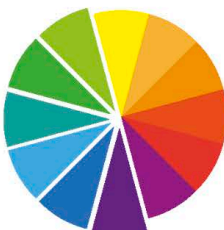
Analogous with

complementary: Similar to an Analogous colour scheme, but with the addition of a complementary primary colour. The addition of a complementary colour provides a nice contrast to the analogous colour grouping.



Triadic:

A triadic or triangle uses three colours that are evenly spaced out around the colour wheel. This offers a strong contrast while retaining a harmony among the colours. On the colour wheel above, every fourth colour is grouped.



Temperature:

The temperature of a colour can usually be described as cool or warm. You can split the colour wheel in half between the green, blue, and blue-violet – cool – side and the yellow, red, and red-violet – warm – side. Cool colours will tend to recede and do well in the background while warm colours will advance and give the feeling of closeness.



WARM



Tint, shade, and tone:

When you add white to a colour it is called a tint of the colour and when you add black to a colour it is called a shade of a colour. Adding both black and white to a colour is called a tone of the colour and will leave the colour with a grey quality.